

Academic Reading: Men and Gender Equality

Text: Ellemers, N. (2018). Gender Stereotypes. *Annual Review of Psychology* 69, p. 275-298. <https://doi.org/10.1146/annurev-psych-122216-011719>.

Task 1: Before reading, discuss these questions (5 min):

- “Women are from Venus, men are from Mars”. What do you think that phrase means? Is it accurate?
- To what extent do you think the differences between women and men are innate, and to what extent are they socialised?
- Why do you think gender stereotypes persist?

Task 2: Skim the extracts below to see what the text says (5 min).

“Women are from Venus, men are from Mars” is a phrase that is often used to explain observed differences in the way women and men think, feel, and act. It conveys the inevitability of such differences by suggesting that men and women originate from planets that are millions of miles apart, implying that they are as inherently different as they would be if they were separate species. There is no denying that there are differences between men and women in many life domains. The question, however, is to what extent these differences reflect the way men and women essentially are, and to what extent they result from how we think men and women differ from each other because of gender stereotypes. (p. 276)

There is no denying that there are differences between men and women in many life domains. The question, however, is to what extent these differences reflect the way men and women essentially are, and to what extent they result from how we think men and women differ from each other because of gender stereotypes. Identifying the nature and content of gender stereotypes clarifies the fact that they not only describe typical differences between men and women, but also prescribe what men and women should be and how they should behave in different life domains. (p. 276)

Gender is considered a primary feature in person perception. Children and adults immediately and implicitly cluster unknown individuals by their gender, even when this categorization is not relevant to the situation and has no informational benefits. Furthermore, gender continues to be seen as a binary categorization, in which we tend to compare men to women and women to men, anchoring any differences in terms of a contrast between them. Thus, gender categorizations are immediately detected, are chronically salient, seem relatively fixed, and are easily polarized. This contributes to the formation and persistence of gender stereotypes and reinforces perceptions of differences between men and women. (p. 277)

Task 3: Match the words & definitions below – this is useful topic vocabulary which can be used in your writing & academic interaction class (5 min).

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| Agency (n) | • | • Equality of rights & opportunities |
| Communality (n) | • | • Chemicals produced to regulate the body |
| Segregation (n) | • | • A spirit of cooperation & mutual commitment |
| Egalitarian (adj) | • | • A central or basic part of something |
| Oxytocin (n) | • | • Production of results through action |
| Kernal (n) | • | • Being set apart; separated |
| Hormone (n) | • | • A hormone which assists in childcare |

Task 4: Read section “2.1. A Kernel of Truth?” on pgs. 277-278 & take notes in the following table (15 min):

Female/Male Differences Examples	Rebuttal

Task 5: Find the answers to the questions in the sections below (25 mins):

2.2. Helpful or Harmful? (p. 278-9)

- 1) What are the problems of stereotypes:
 - a. In general?
 - b. For women in an educational context?
 - c. For women in employability/working contexts?
 - d. For women regarding promotion?
- 2) For men?

2.4. Gendered Expectations (p. 280-1)

- 3) What does the author say about stereotypes and physical appearance?
- 4) How can they influence us when we are trying to ‘appear attractive’, romantically?
- 5) Research shows that both women and men report similar problems combining work and family life. Why, therefore, does parenthood affect women’s careers, but not men’s?

3. Making Sense of the World (p. 282)

- 6) What is the function of stereotypes?
- 7) Why are they unlikely to change?

3.2. Communication (p. 283-6)

- 8) How are stereotypes communicated:
 - a. To children?
 - b. Via the media?
 - c. Linguistically?
- 9) How does physical body posture affect gender stereotypes?
- 10) How does the way emotions are expressed affect this?

4. Resilience to Change (p. 287-8)

- 11) How do gender stereotypes limit us, and why do people still conform to them?

4.2. The Motivation to Believe the World is Just (p. 288-9)

- 12) What happens when people believe that stereotypical task performance and life choices are their own individual choices?

4.3. The Motivation to Act Effectively (p. 289)

- 13) What are some consequences women can face when challenging the status quo?

4.4. The Discomfort of Privilege (p.290)

- 14) How does privilege explain opposition to gender equality, particularly from men?

Task 6: Based on your understanding of the reading, as well as your personal experience and views, discuss the following questions in groups (15 mins):

- A. Can there be gender equality whilst these stereotypes persist?
- B. Look at the quotes from the text below and discuss how they affect society and/or the progress of gender equality:

“Gender stereotypes thus not only capture how we expect men and women to behave, but also communicate how we think they should behave.”

“When professional and life roles do not fit gender stereotypical expectations, this inconsistency impacts perceived self-efficacy and restricts life choices for both women and men.”

“As long as people perceive gender-stereotypical task preferences and life choices—including their own—as individual choices, they can maintain the conviction that men

and women have equal opportunities and can make counter-stereotypical choices if they want to do so.”

- C. Gender stereotypes also affect men negatively; can you think of some examples from the text or elsewhere?
- D. Moves such as anti-discrimination training and hiring quotas in companies, although aiming to improve female representation and treatment, seem to be ineffective. Can you think of any ways to overcome the stereotypes?